job for the Australians. Aussie coaches would feed tennis balls, encased in leather, into a bowling machine set to aim at the head at 100 mph.

Those sessions were brutal and drew blood. Only Ricky seemed immune to punishment; he was never hit and swiped away deliveries in front of square leg. To me, as a twenty-one-year-old breaking into the England team, he was different gravy. He seemed to have so much time to hook and pull the ball, getting his foot down the pitch early. He struck it so crisply and cleanly.

His 196 against us in the Brisbane Test in 2006 stays with me as the perfect example of his willpower, skill and defiance. He batted for more than seven and a half hours, across two days, before Matthew Hoggard trapped him leg before. He reached 100 in 136 balls, retrenched and survived another 186 deliveries before he left, visibly angry, swishing his bat across the turf at his perceived casualness.

He thirsted for more, having blotted out all the pre-match noise. He was measured in defence, barely played a false stroke and used his feet brilliantly. The local press, in typical trampoline fashion, compared him to Bradman a couple of days after questioning his capacity to lead his country. I saw someone operating at a higher level, batting on a different planet from the rest of us.

Kallis was a complete cricketer, capable of catching pigeons at slip and amassing 292 Test wickets. His batting, ruthless and serene, enabled him to accumulate 13,289 Test runs at an average in excess of 55. His technique had such simplicity and repeatability. His temperament ensured he never looked flustered. He could control matches single-handedly.

I played against Lara only once, for MCC at Arundel in July 2004. He was recovering from a two-day bout of flu, and laced his 113, from 105 balls, with eighteen fours and two sixes. We probably got off lightly, since his four previous first-class innings were 400 not out, 53, 120 and another 113. He retired ill, complaining about his physical fragility and the strength of our team.

He took Min Patel, a wily slow left-arm spin bowler who was good enough to make two Test appearances for England eight years earlier, to the cleaners on a turning wicket. I had just been named England’s Under-19 captain, and so wouldn’t have been on Lara’s radar, and was in danger of succumbing to a bout of hero worship.